Ruşen Birben

AI Researcher & Engineer

Ankara, Turkey birben20@itu.edu.tr rusen.ai

github.com/rusenbb linkedin.com/in/rusenbirben kaggle.com/rusenbirben

AI and Data Engineering graduate from Istanbul Technical University and independent researcher with METU's Applied NLP Group. Research interests center on LLM reliability and interpretability, with experience in Turkish NLP, machine unlearning, and LLM applications for finance.

EDUCATION

B.Sc. AI and Data Engineering 2022 - 2025
Istanbul Technical University GPA: 3.61 / 4.00

Undergraduate studies in Electronics & Communication Engineering 2020 - 2022
Istanbul Technical University
Transferred to AI & Data Engineering

SCHOLARSHIPS & AWARDS

1416 YLSY Scholarship · M.Sc. & Ph.D. 2026
Awarded government funding for overseas master's study followed by doctoral study, covering tuition fees, a monthly living stipend, health insurance, travel, language-exam fees, and study supplies. Following completion of the funded studies, will return to Türkiye as an assistant professor.

Kaggle Bronze Medal · The Pokémon Company PTCG AI Battle Challenge 2026
Ranked 677th of 6,807 teams (top 10%) in Kaggle's simulation competition, developing and evaluating partially observable game-playing agents with replay-based behavioral cloning, belief-aware Monte Carlo planning, and self-play.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Independent Researcher 03/2026 - Present
METU Applied NLP Group Ankara, TR

- Co-organize the SIGTURK 2027 Shared Task at the SIGTURK 2027 Workshop (ACL 2027) with Çağrı Toraman and Evren Ayberk Munis. Contribute to data creation and evaluation methodology; built the shared-task website and evaluation pipeline.
- Support LlamaTurk2 through training-data collection and pretraining experiments.
- Lead METU NLP Connect, producing expert interviews.

AIOps Research Intern 08/2024 - 09/2024
Havelsan Istanbul, TR

- Investigated software-log analysis for predictive maintenance; developed prototypes using HDFS logs.

NLP Research Intern 07/2024 - 08/2024
ITU NLP Lab Istanbul, TR

- Researched financial LLM applications involving sentiment analysis, tool use, reasoning, forecasting, and retrieval-augmented generation. Contributed experiments to the Kaira undergraduate capstone.

PUBLICATIONS & RESEARCH CONTRIBUTIONS

Turkish Cultural Knowledge Dataset - MRL 2026 2026
Accepted dataset contribution; joint benchmark paper in preparation Shared Task

- Led the source-grounded agent pipeline and data preparation for a Turkish cultural knowledge dataset spanning 15 domains.
- Screened 1,200 candidate question-answer pairs; selected 500 for sociological review by Büşra Tufan and prepared the final 300-pair submission.
- Contributed to English translation review under the research guidance of Çağrı Toraman.

SELECTED PROJECTS

Kaira
2025

Undergraduate Capstone: Financial Reasoning LLM

- Fine-tuned Qwen-based LLMs with GRPO, Unsloth, and LoRA; ran FinQA and GSM8K experiments on reward design and financial reasoning. Developed an Ollama-based chat application.

Tobor
2024 - 2025

Autonomous Warehouse Robot Code Video

- Implemented the box pickup/drop-off mechanism in a team-built ROS2 warehouse robot with navigation and YOLO perception; shared data annotation and supported other algorithms.

AIZheimer
2024

Machine Unlearning in Stable Diffusion Code

- Adapted Forget-Me-Not-based unlearning for Stable Diffusion 2.1. Implemented attention controllers and explored loss objectives; qualitatively assessed concept removal and retention of unrelated generation capabilities.

Biting The Bytes
2024

Turkish Diacritic Restoration Code Demo

- Led ByT5-small training and hyperparameter tuning with PEFT/LoRA for byte-level Turkish diacritic restoration. Shared debugging and Hugging Face Spaces deployment with a teammate.

To-AI-or-Not-to-AI
2023

GPT Detector Code Demo

- Combined three fine-tuned RoBERTa detectors by majority vote. Shared preparation of 26,270 examples; achieved 94.21% accuracy on an in-domain random split, without establishing out-of-domain generalization.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Co-Founder & Technical Lead
08/2025 - 04/2026

Fiction Studios Ankara, TR

- Co-founded Fiction Studios at Bilkent Cyberpark; led technical development and coordinated three additional contributors. Built a multilingual LLM-powered museum and tourism guide, alongside customer and investor discussions.

Junior AI Engineer
03/2025 - 07/2025

CyberQuote Istanbul, TR

- Developed news-sentiment pipelines, internal financial LLM tools, web integrations, and a mobile voice assistant at a Phillip Capital subsidiary. Worked on retrieving current context from fragmented sources and PDF reports.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Languages Python / JavaScript/TypeScript / SQL / C/C++

Frameworks & Tools PyTorch / TensorFlow / Transformers / PEFT / LoRA / Unsloth / Scikit-learn / Pandas / NumPy / ROS2 / YOLO

Specialties NLP / LLMs / RAG / Machine Unlearning / Model Evaluation

COURSES / LANGUAGES

Deep Learning Specialization DeepLearning.AI · Coursera

AWS Cloud Technical Essentials AWS · Coursera

Turkish Native **English** TOEFL iBT 109/120 (November 8, 2025)

Interests: Coffee / Books / Photography / Anime & Manga